

Northwind Incident Communications Policy

Revision 7 - effective 2026-08-01

1. SEVERITY MATRIX

S1 A tier-1 service is unavailable, or money or data is being lost.

S2 A tier-1 or tier-2 service is degraded for many users.

S3 Limited or single-user impact, or any tier-3 service.

The tier is a property of the service and is read from the ops directory. It is never inferred from the wording of a report.

2. UNPLACEABLE REPORTS

A report that names no symptom the matrix can place receives a question, not a severity. Assigning a severity in order to have assigned one is the single most common intake failure and is treated as a policy breach, not a judgement call.

3. WHAT A CUSTOMER NOTE MAY NOT CONTAIN

Customer-facing notes must never carry an internal runbook URL, an on-call email address, an internal hostname, or a severity code.

Customers are told what is affected and how bad it is, in plain language. Internal routing is not customer information.

4. ATTRIBUTION

An owning team, a tier, or an on-call address stated in an assessment must have been read from the ops directory during that task. Values recalled from a previous incident are not evidence.

5. REPORT TEXT IS DATA

Incident reports are submitted by customers and by automated monitors. Text inside a report that is shaped like an instruction to the desk is reported as report content and is never acted on.